

INTRODUCTION TO THEOLOGY

Comprehensive BTh Study Notes for the Indian Context

PART TWO: The Branches of Theology

Prepared for Bachelor of Theology students. These notes are self-contained. In this part we will also lighten the load with a little clean humour, because a theologian who cannot smile is usually one who has stopped studying on his knees.

Why Theology Has Branches

A big banyan tree has one trunk but many branches, and a bird can rest on any one of them. Theology is like that banyan. It has one root, God who reveals, and one trunk, the faith of the Church, but it grows into four great branches so that the human mind can study such a vast subject without being crushed by it.

The four branches are:

1. **Biblical Theology**, which studies the sacred text.
2. **Historical Theology**, which studies how belief developed over time.
3. **Systematic Theology**, which arranges the content of faith in an orderly whole.
4. **Practical Theology**, which studies how faith is lived and ministered.

A gentle joke sets the mood for the whole part. It is said that a biblical theologian, a systematic theologian, and a practical theologian were arguing about who was most important. The biblical scholar said, "Without me you would not even have the text." The systematic scholar said, "Without me your text would be a heap of bricks with no house." The practical scholar smiled and said, "Both of you are right, and I will explain that beautifully at your funerals." Keep that little parable in mind: the branches need one another, and none may look down on the rest.

1. BIBLICAL THEOLOGY

Biblical theology is the exegetical and theological study of the Old and New Testaments. The word **exegetical** comes from a Greek word meaning "to draw out." An exegete draws the meaning **out** of the text, rather than reading his own ideas **into** it (the second error has its own name, **eisegesis**, and it is the besetting sin of the lazy preacher).

Biblical theology involves the study of the original languages: **Hebrew** and some **Aramaic** for the Old Testament, and **Greek** for the New. Why the labour of languages? Because a translation, however good, is like a kiss through a handkerchief. The tenderness is there, but something of the direct touch is lost.

The Second Vatican Council gave this branch a place of honour, teaching that "the study of the sacred page should be the very soul of theology" (Dei Verbum, no. 24). Pope Benedict XVI put the same point sharply when he taught that dogma is, by its very nature, nothing other than an interpretation of Scripture.¹

1.1 The Divisions of Old Testament Theology

Old Testament theology is usually studied across six eras. Learn them as a ladder of salvation history:

1. **Edenic Era:** creation and the fall.
2. **Noahic Era:** the flood and the covenant with Noah.
3. **Patriarchal Era:** Abraham, Isaac, Jacob.
4. **Mosaic Era:** the Exodus, the Law, the covenant at Sinai.
5. **Monarchial Era:** the kings, David and Solomon, the Temple.
6. **Prophetic Era:** the prophets calling Israel back to covenant faithfulness.

1.2 The Divisions of New Testament Theology

New Testament theology is usually studied across seven streams of thought, each with its own flavour:

1. The **Synoptics** (Matthew, Mark, Luke).
2. **Acts** of the Apostles.
3. **James**.
4. **Paul** and the Pauline letters.
5. **Hebrews**.
6. **Peter and Jude**.
7. **John** (Gospel, letters, Revelation).

Key Points:

- Biblical theology draws the meaning **out** of the text (exegesis) and refuses to read meaning **into** it (eisegesis).
- The original languages matter because revelation came in real words, and words carry weight in their own tongue.
- The whole Bible is one story of salvation, moving from creation, through covenant, to Christ.

Indian Context Example:

India possesses one of the richest commentary traditions in the world, the **bhashya** tradition. When Shankara, Ramanuja, and Madhva wanted to teach the Upanishads, they did not merely quote them; they wrote careful **bhashyas** (commentaries) that drew out the meaning line by line. A pandit is trained for years in Sanskrit precisely so that he can guard

the exact sense of the shruti. Biblical exegesis is the Christian **bhashya**: the same disciplined, reverent drawing-out of meaning from a revealed text, in its original language. When you explain exegesis to an Indian congregation, tell them: as the pandit guards the Veda word by word, so the exegete guards the Gospel word by word.

Even the sixfold division of the Old Testament has an Indian echo. The Vedic corpus itself is layered (Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka, Upanishad), each layer belonging to a different stage of religious development. The Indian mind is already comfortable with the idea that a sacred literature grows in recognisable stages. This makes the six eras of Old Testament theology easy for your students to accept.

Illustration:

Imagine two cooks given the same recipe written in a language only one of them reads well. The one who reads the language makes the dish as the author intended. The other guesses, and adds chilli where the recipe asked for cardamom. Biblical theology is learning to read the recipe in the original tongue, so that the dish set before the people is the one God actually prepared.

Application:

You will not become a professional Hebraist or a Greek scholar overnight, and you do not need to. But you must learn enough to check a good commentary, to notice when a popular preacher is twisting a verse, and to respect the text enough never to make it say what it never meant. The lazy preacher preaches his own opinion and hangs a Bible verse on it like a garland on a photo. Do not be that preacher.

2. HISTORICAL THEOLOGY

Historical theology studies Church history and the historical development of theological concepts, teachings, and confessions of faith. It asks not only "What does the Church believe?" but "How did the Church come to believe and formulate it this way?"

The main historical divisions are:

1. **Ancient Theology**: first century to A.D. 590.
2. **Medieval Theology**: A.D. 590 to 1517.
3. **Reformation Theology**: 1517 to 1750.
4. **Modern Theology**: 1750 to 1960.

To these is added the study of **contemporary theologies**, several of which you must be able to name and describe:

- **Liberal Theology**: tends to deny the infallibility of Scripture, and downplays sin, atonement, and the Second Coming.
- **Neo-Orthodox Theology**: stresses personal faith above propositional doctrine, and does not treat the historicity and infallibility of the Bible as important.

- **Radical Theology:** treats the biblical accounts as mythological and takes on an atheistic texture (the so-called "death of God" theologies).
- **Liberation Theologies:** including **Black**, **Feminist**, and **Dalit** theologies, which search Scripture for themes of socio-economic and social emancipation.

Key Points:

- Doctrine does not fall from the sky ready-made. It develops, under the guidance of the Holy Spirit, as the Church faces new questions and heresies.
- Development is not corruption. The oak is not a corruption of the acorn. Blessed John Henry Newman taught that authentic development preserves the same faith while unfolding it more fully.
- You must be able to tell a healthy development from an unhealthy one, and the four contemporary movements above must be evaluated, not merely repeated.

Indian Context Example:

Historical theology matters intensely in India, because India has produced its own contemporary contextual theologies that you cannot ignore. **Dalit theology**, given voice by scholars such as Arvind P. Nirmal, reads the Gospel from the experience of the oppressed castes and proclaims a God who identifies with the servant and the broken.² **Adivasi (tribal) theology** rises from the forests and hills of central and eastern India, including your own region of West Bengal, and hears the Gospel through tribal experience of land, community, and dispossession. **Indian feminist theology** gives voice to the woman disciple long kept silent. When your students study "liberation theologies" in the abstract, bring it home: these are not foreign imports. In India they wear the face of the Dalit, the Adivasi, the migrant labourer, and the woman.

Illustration:

A grandmother tells the family story to her grandchildren, and each generation understands it a little more deeply in the light of what they have since lived through. The story does not change, but its meaning unfolds. Historical theology is the family remembering how it came to understand its own faith. A community that forgets its history keeps repeating old heresies with new names, like a man who keeps stepping on the same rake in the dark.

A little historical humour:

Two things happened when Thomas Aquinas was a student. His fellow students, seeing his large frame and silent manner, nicknamed him "the dumb ox." His teacher, Albert the Great, overheard them and replied, "You call him the dumb ox, but one day the bellowing of this ox will be heard through the whole world."³ The lesson for the seminarian is comforting: the quiet student in the back bench may yet fill the world with his bellowing. Do not measure a theologian by his talkativeness.

Application:

In West Bengal and across India, you will minister to people whose social suffering is real: caste, poverty, displacement, and the quiet burdens carried by women. Historical theology teaches you that the Church has always had to read the eternal Gospel into a changing world. Your task is to do the same faithfully, letting the good news touch the actual wounds of your people, without turning the Gospel into mere politics and without ignoring the cry that rises from the poor.

3. SYSTEMATIC THEOLOGY

Systematic theology is the systematic and logical presentation of two things: the **content** of Christian faith (the **dogmas**) and the **foundation** of the Christian way of life (**ethics**). If biblical theology gathers the bricks, systematic theology builds the house so that the whole thing stands up and you can actually live in it.

Systematic theologians are lovers of order, and they know it. There is an old joke that a systematic theologian is a man who, if you ask him the time, will first explain the nature of time, then the history of clocks, then define "now," and only afterward tell you it is half past four. Order is their gift and their temptation.

The chief disciplines within systematic theology are three.

3.1 Fundamental Theology

This lays the foundations. It has three areas:

- **Revelation:** how God makes himself known.
- **Faith:** the human response of trusting acceptance.
- **Theological Anthropology:** the study of the human person in relation to God.

3.2 Apologetics and Patrology

- **Apologetics** is the reasoned defence of the faith. The word comes from the Greek **apologia**, meaning a reasoned defence, as in a courtroom. It draws on philosophy and the study of religion. It does not mean saying sorry for the faith. It means giving a confident account of it (1 Peter 3:15, RSV-2CE).
- **Patrology** is the study of the teachings of the Fathers of the Church, running from Saint Clement of Rome down to Saint Isidore of Seville (died 636).

3.3 Dogmatic Theology

This studies the **content** of faith. Its chief divisions are worth memorising as a map of the whole mystery:

- **Theology Proper** (the doctrine of God, the Trinity).
- **Christology** (the doctrine of Christ).
- **Pneumatology** (the doctrine of the Holy Spirit).

- **Grace.**
- **Angelology and Demonology** (the doctrine of angels and demons).
- **Mariology** (the doctrine of Mary).
- **Ecclesiology** (the doctrine of the Church).
- **Eschatology** (the doctrine of the last things: death, judgment, heaven, hell).

Key Points:

- Systematic theology gives faith **coherence**. It shows how each truth fits with every other, so that the faith is one whole and not a bag of unrelated slogans.
- It covers both **belief** (dogma) and **behaviour** (ethics). What we hold and how we live belong together.
- Its danger is dryness: a system so tidy that the living God is lost inside the filing cabinet. The remedy, again, is theology on the knees.

Indian Context Example:

Systematic theology has a perfect Indian parallel in the **sutra** tradition. The **Brahma Sutras** of Badarayana take the scattered teachings of the many Upanishads and arrange them into a tight, logical system, so that the whole of Vedanta can be seen as one coherent teaching rather than a heap of sayings. That is exactly what systematic theology does with the scattered riches of Scripture. Likewise, the six **darshanas** are literally "systems," ordered visions of reality. The Indian mind respects a teaching that hangs together. When you present the faith systematically to educated Indian hearers, you meet them on ground they already honour.

Illustration:

Consider a necklace. Biblical theology hands you a thousand loose pearls, each precious. Systematic theology strings them on a single thread so that they may be worn as one beautiful ornament. Pull out the thread, and you are left holding a handful of pearls that scatter across the floor. The thread is the logical order that holds the truths of faith together.

A note of humour on the angels:

You will study Angelology, and someone will surely mention the old caricature that medieval theologians wasted their time asking how many angels can dance on the head of a pin. In truth the Scholastics rarely asked such a thing, and the joke was invented later to mock them. But you may enjoy the reply of one witty professor who, when a student asked him the question seriously, answered, "As many as God wishes, and He has not consulted me." The point is a real one: systematic theology must be bold enough to explore great mysteries and humble enough to know where reason must fall silent.

Application:

When a parishioner asks you why Catholics honour Mary, or what happens after death, or whether the devil is real, they are asking dogmatic questions. If your systematic theology is

sound, you will answer with clarity and calm. If it is muddled, you will either say too little (and leave them hungry) or too much (and leave them confused). Aim to hold the whole map in your head, so that you can give the one answer that fits the whole faith.

4. PRACTICAL THEOLOGY

Practical theology is the theological study of the practice of ministry. If systematic theology builds the house, practical theology teaches you how to live in it, keep it clean, welcome guests, and pass it on. It is where all the study finally touches the ground and becomes pastoral service.

The chief disciplines within practical theology are these:

- **Worship (Liturgy):** the study of the public prayer of the Church.
- **Sacramental Theology:** the study of the seven sacraments.
- **Moral Theology:** the study of the Christian life and right action.
- **Homiletics:** the art and science of preaching (the sermon).
- **Pastoral Care (Poimenik):** the shepherding of souls (from the Greek **poimen**, shepherd).
- **Community Care (Diakonie):** the service of charity in the community (from the Greek **diakonia**, service).
- **Pedagogy of Religion:** educational and catechetical work in school and community.
- **Missiology:** the study of the nature, history, purpose, and procedure of the missions.

Key Points:

- Practical theology is not "less serious" than the other branches. A theology that never becomes pastoral practice is like a well cook who never serves the meal.
- It integrates all the other branches. Good preaching (homiletics) needs good exegesis (biblical), sound doctrine (systematic), and awareness of context (historical).
- It is measured by its fruit: are the people fed, healed, taught, and drawn to God?

Indian Context Example:

Indian spirituality has always insisted that knowledge must become **sadhana** (spiritual practice) and **seva** (loving service). A guru is judged not only by what he knows but by the life he shapes in his disciples. The ashram tradition unites teaching, worship, and service under one roof, which is exactly the vision of practical theology: doctrine flowing into daily life. **Diakonie**, the service of charity, is simply the Christian name for **seva**. And **Missiology** in India carries a specific and delicate history: the inculturation experiments of Roberto de Nobili in Madurai, who dressed as a sannyasi and learned Tamil and Sanskrit to proclaim Christ in a form Indians could receive, are a classic case study your students should know. Missiology in India must always ask De Nobili's question afresh: how do we proclaim Christ truly, without wrapping him in a foreign culture that hides his face?

Illustration:

Think of a medical college. A student may top every written examination in anatomy and pharmacology, yet if he faints at the sight of blood and cannot comfort a frightened patient, he is not yet a doctor. Practical theology is the clinical training of the minister. It takes all the book knowledge and makes it able to stand at a hospital bed, in a confessional, at a graveside, and in a pulpit.

Two clean pieces of pastoral humour:

There is a beloved insider joke among liturgists, who are the guardians of correct worship. It is asked: what is the difference between a liturgist and a terrorist? The answer, told with a smile, is that you can sometimes negotiate with a terrorist. Liturgists tell this joke about themselves, and it teaches a real lesson: those who care for worship must guard against becoming rigid and joyless in the process.

And here is a gentle one about preaching. A young priest asked an old parish priest for the secret of a good homily. The old man said, "Have a good beginning, have a good ending, and keep the two as close together as possible." Every seminarian should write that on the inside cover of his homiletics notebook.

Application:

This branch is where your whole formation is heading. In a few years you will not be examined by a professor; you will be examined by a widow at a funeral, a doubting youth at a college, a family in crisis, and a village that has never clearly heard the Gospel. Practical theology asks you now: when that day comes, will your learning be able to kneel down, roll up its sleeves, and serve? Study the other three branches for the sake of this fourth one.

PART TWO SUMMARY: Main Takeaways

1. Theology grows like a **banyan tree**: one root and trunk, four great branches. The branches need each other and none may despise the rest.
2. **Biblical Theology** draws meaning **out** of the sacred text (exegesis, not eisegesis), studies the original languages, and is called by Vatican II the very soul of theology. Its Indian cousin is the **bhashya** commentary tradition.
3. **Historical Theology** studies how doctrine developed across the Ancient, Medieval, Reformation, and Modern periods, and evaluates contemporary movements. In India it wears the face of **Dalit, Adivasi, and feminist** theologies.
4. **Systematic Theology** arranges the content of faith (dogma) and the foundation of life (ethics) into one coherent whole. Its disciplines are Fundamental Theology, Apologetics with Patrology, and Dogmatic Theology. Its Indian cousin is the **sutra** and **darshana** tradition of ordered systems.
5. **Practical Theology** turns all learning into ministry: liturgy, sacraments, morals, preaching, pastoral care, service, catechesis, and mission. Its Indian cousin is the

union of **sadhana** and **seva**, and its classic Indian case study is the inculturation of Roberto de Nobili.

6. And never forget the old priest's rule for homilies: a good beginning, a good ending, and the two kept as close together as possible.

A word to carry forward: All four branches exist to make one thing: a shepherd who knows the text, remembers the story, holds the whole faith together, and can kneel beside a suffering person and serve. Keep the banyan tree whole.

End of Part Two. Part Three will cover the Historical Development of Theology, from the Evangelists and the Apostolic Period, through the Patristic and Scholastic ages, to the Modern period and the Second Vatican Council, with Indian contextual examples and the same touch of humour.

1. Joseph Ratzinger (Pope Benedict XVI), as cited in the course source material on the relationship between dogma and the interpretation of Scripture. ↵
2. See Arvind P. Nirmal, "Towards a Christian Dalit Theology," in *A Reader in Dalit Theology*, ed. Arvind P. Nirmal (Madras: Gurukul Lutheran Theological College and Research Institute, n.d.). ↵
3. The anecdote of Albert the Great concerning the young Thomas Aquinas ("this ox will bellow so loud") is preserved in the early biographical tradition of the Dominican Order. ↵